

# Word family: \*\*flat / flatter / flattest / flatten / flattened / flatly / flatness\*\*

\*\*Base word:\*\* flat

\*\*Comparative:\*\* flatter

\*\*Superlative:\*\* flattest

\*\*Related forms:\*\* flatten, flattened, flatly, flatness

\*\*Part of speech:\*\* adjective ( 形容詞 ) / noun ( 名詞 ) / adverb-related uses ( 相關副詞用法 )

Your sentence:

> “He can move from a serious topic to a witty remark in a heartbeat, so conversations with him never feel \*\*flat\*\*.”

## Meaning in this passage

Here, \*\*flat\*\* means \*\*dull, lifeless, lacking energy, variety, emotional impact, or interest\*\*.

The speaker means conversations with Mr. Wong never become monotonous or lacking in vitality.

\*\*繁體中文\*\*： \*\*缺乏活力、變化、情感或吸引力，因此令人覺得沉悶、單調或沒有生氣的\*\*

\*\*中文翻譯\*\*：

> “...conversations with him never feel \*\*flat\*\*.”

「.....所以和他聊天從來不會令人覺得\*\*沉悶、單調或沒有生氣\*\*。」

Here:

\*\*flat conversation = 缺乏活力、變化或吸引力，令人覺得沉悶的談話\*\*

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# 1. \*\*flat = level / not curved or raised ( 表面 / 形狀 ) — 平的；平坦的\*\*

This is the basic physical meaning.

\*\*Meaning:\*\* Having an even, level surface without significant curves, slopes, bumps, or raised parts.

### Practice 1

> “Put the box on a \*\*flat\*\* surface.”

「把盒子放在一個\*\*平坦的表面\*\*上。」

### ### Practice 2

> “The land around the village is very **flat**.”

「村莊周圍的土地非常**平坦**。」

**flat** = 表面或地形沒有明顯彎曲、隆起、凹凸或斜坡的

Common:

\* flat surface

\* flat ground

\* flat roof

\* flat screen

These belong to one physical shape sense.

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# 2. **flat** = lying horizontally / pressed down ( 位置 / 形態 ) — 平放的 ; 貼平的

A person or object can be **flat** when lying fully against a surface.

### ### Practice 3

> “She lay **flat** on the floor.”

「她**平躺**在地板上。」

### ### Practice 4

> “Press the paper **flat** against the table.”

「把紙張**壓平**在桌面上。」

**flat** = 整個表面平放或貼在另一個表面上，沒有豎起或突出

For database counting, I would merge this with Meaning 1 under the broader physical concept:

> **level / not raised / not projecting**

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# 3. **flat** = dull / lifeless / lacking energy or interest ( 談話 / 表演 / 氣氛 ) — 沉悶的 ; 沒有生氣的

This is the meaning used in your passage.

**\*\*Meaning:\*\*** Lacking energy, emotional force, variation, excitement, or impact.

#### ### Practice 5 — Original

> “Conversations with him never feel **\*\*flat\*\***.”

「和他聊天從來不會令人覺得**\*\*沉悶、單調或沒有生氣\*\***。」

#### ### Practice 6

> “The speech started well but became rather **\*\*flat\*\***.”

「演講開始得不錯，但後來變得相當**\*\*沉悶乏味\*\***。」

#### ### Practice 7

> “The performance felt emotionally **\*\*flat\*\***.”

「那場表演在情感上顯得**\*\*缺乏起伏、沒有感染力\*\***。」

**\*\*flat = 缺乏活力、變化、情感或吸引力，因此令人覺得單調或沒有感染力\*\***

Common:

- \* flat conversation
- \* flat performance
- \* flat atmosphere
- \* flat delivery
- \* flat joke

These are one figurative sense.

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# 4. **\*\*flat = without emotional expression ( 聲音 / 語氣 ) — 平淡的；沒有感情的\*\***

A voice or tone can be **\*\*flat\*\*** when it lacks emotional variation.

#### ### Practice 8

> “He answered in a **\*\*flat\*\*** voice.”

「他用**\*\*平淡而沒有感情的語氣\*\***回答。」

### ### Practice 9

> “Her delivery sounded strangely **flat**.”

「她的說話方式聽起來異常**平淡、缺乏情緒起伏**。」

**flat voice/tone** = 語氣缺乏高低、情緒或表達力，聽起來平淡沒有生氣

This is closely related to Meaning 3.

For core counting, I would **merge it into the dull/lifeless sense**, because the underlying concept is still:

> **lack of variation and expressive energy**

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# 5. **flat** = no longer fizzy/carbonated ( 飲品 ) — 走氣的；沒有氣泡的

This is a genuinely different meaning.

### ### Practice 10

> “The cola has gone **flat**.”

「這杯可樂已經**走氣、沒有氣泡**了。」

### ### Practice 11

> “I don’t like **flat** sparkling water.”

「我不喜歡已經**沒有氣的有氣水**。」

**flat drink** = 原本應有氣泡或二氧化碳，但氣體已流失，不再有氣泡感的飲品

This is a common everyday use.

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# 6. **flat** = discharged / no electrical power ( 電池 ) — 沒電的

Especially in British English, a battery can be **flat** when it has no usable electrical charge left.

### ### Practice 12

> “My phone battery is completely **flat**.”

「我的手機電池已經完全\*\*沒電\*\*。」

#### ### Practice 13

> “The car wouldn’t start because the battery was \*\*flat\*\*.”

「汽車發動不了，因為電池\*\*沒電了\*\*。」

**\*\*flat battery = 電池已沒有足夠電力，無法正常供電\*\***

#### ### Regional note

This is especially common in British English.

American English more often says:

> **\*\*dead battery\*\***

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# 7. **\*\*flat = deflated ( 輪胎 ) — 洩氣的；扁掉的\*\***

A **\*\*flat tyre/tire\*\*** has lost its air pressure.

#### ### Practice 14

> “We had to stop because one of the tyres was \*\*flat\*\*.”

「我們不得不停車，因為其中一個輪胎\*\*洩了氣 / 扁了\*\*。」

#### ### Practice 15

> “He discovered a **\*\*flat tyre\*\*** before leaving for work.”

「他上班前發現有一個**\*\*洩氣的輪胎\*\***。」

**\*\*flat tyre = 因失去空氣或氣壓而無法保持正常形狀的輪胎\*\***

This is distinct enough to keep because the practical learner meaning is very specific.

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# 8. **\*\*flat = lower in musical pitch ( 音樂 ) — 降音的；偏低的\*\***

In music, **\*\*flat\*\*** has an established technical meaning.

#### ### Practice 16

> “B **flat** is written with the symbol  $\flat$ .”

「B **降音**寫作  $B\flat$ 。」

#### ### Practice 17

> “That note sounded slightly **flat**.”

「那個音聽起來有點**偏低**。」

**flat** = 音高比正常或指定音高低半音；亦可指演奏或唱出的音比正確音高稍低

This is a genuinely distinct music sense.

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# 9. **flat** = fixed / uniform without variation ( 價格 / 收費 ) — 固定的；劃一的

In expressions such as **flat rate** or **flat fee**, **flat** means the amount does not vary according to usage, time, quantity, etc.

#### ### Practice 18

> “The hotel charges a **flat fee** for parking.”

「酒店收取一筆**固定泊車費**。」

#### ### Practice 19

> “Customers pay a **flat rate** each month.”

「顧客每月支付一個**劃一固定費用**。」

**flat rate/fee** = 不因使用量、時間或其他條件而改變的固定金額

This develops from the broader idea of:

> **no variation**

but it is common enough in business and everyday English to teach explicitly.

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# 10. \*\*a flat ( British English housing ) — 公寓 ; 單位\*\*

As a noun, \*\*flat\*\* means an apartment.

#### ### Practice 20

> “She rents a small \*\*flat\*\* near the station.”

「她在車站附近租了一個小\*\*公寓 / 單位\*\*。」

#### ### Practice 21

> “They moved into a new \*\*flat\*\* last month.”

「他們上個月搬進了一個新的\*\*住宅單位 / 公寓\*\*。」

\*\*a flat = 一組位於較大型建築物內、供一戶人居住的獨立住宅單位\*\*

#### ### Regional note

\*\*British English:\*\* flat

\*\*American English:\*\* apartment

This is clearly a separate noun meaning.

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# 11. \*\*flat = absolute / complete / direct ( 拒絕 / 否定 ) — 完全的 ; 斷然的\*\*

In expressions such as \*\*flat refusal\*\*, \*\*flat denial\*\*, or \*\*flat no\*\*, \*\*flat\*\* emphasizes that something is direct and absolute.

#### ### Practice 22

> “She gave the proposal a \*\*flat refusal\*\*.”

「她對這項建議作出了\*\*斷然拒絕\*\*。」

#### ### Practice 23

> “His answer was a \*\*flat no\*\*.”

「他的回答是\*\*斬釘截鐵地說不\*\*。」

\*\*flat refusal/denial/no = 毫不含糊、完全而直接的拒絕或否定\*\*

This is a useful figurative sense.

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# 12. **flatly** ( 副詞 ) — 斷然地 ; 平淡地

**Flatly** inherits two especially useful ideas from **flat**.

## **flatly** = directly and absolutely

### Practice 24

> “She **flatly** refused to answer.”

「她**斷然拒絕**回答。」

### Practice 25

> “He **flatly** denied the accusation.”

「他**斬釘截鐵地否認**那項指控。」

**flatly** = 以完全、不留餘地而直接的方式

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## **flatly** = without expression

### Practice 26

> “ ‘No,’ she said **flatly**.”

「『不。』她**毫無感情地 / 冷淡地**說。」

**flatly** = 以缺乏情緒、語調變化或表情的方式

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# Related form: **flatten**

**Flatten** means to make or become flat.

### Practice 27

> “Use your hand to **flatten** the dough.”

「用手把麵團\*\*壓平\*\*。」

### ### Practice 28

> “The storm \*\*flattened\*\* several trees.”

「暴風把幾棵樹\*\*吹倒壓平\*\*了。」

**\*\*flatten = 令某物變平、被壓倒或失去原本突出 / 立體形狀\*\***

It also has figurative extensions such as reducing differences or growth, but those belong under the same broad “make flatter / reduce variation” concept unless context requires more detail.

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# Important distinction: **\*\*flat vs level\*\***

### ### **\*\*flat\*\***

focuses on having no bumps, curves, or raised areas.

### ### **\*\*level\*\***

focuses on being horizontal and not sloping.

A surface can be:

> smooth and flat

but still slightly tilted, so not perfectly:

> level

Thus:

**\*\*flat = 平坦\*\***

**\*\*level = 水平、不傾斜\*\***

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# Important distinction: **\*\*flat vs dull\*\***

In your passage they overlap.

### ### **\*\*flat\*\***

often suggests a lack of energy, variation, emotional lift, or impact.

### **\*\*dull\*\***

more generally means boring, uninteresting, or lacking brightness/sharpness.

> “The conversation felt flat.”

= 對話沒有活力、起伏。

> “The lecture was dull.”

= 講座很沉悶。

**\*\*Flat\*\*** often creates a stronger image of something lacking dimension or liveliness.

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# Important distinction: **\*\*flat vs apartment\*\***

In British English:

> **\*\*flat\*\***

is the ordinary word.

In American English:

> **\*\*apartment\*\***

is much more common.

So:

> “I live in a flat.” 

> “I live in an apartment.” 

Same core housing concept.

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# Important distinction: **\*\*flat vs dead\*\***

These overlap in specific contexts but are not general synonyms.

### ### Battery

> flat battery 

> dead battery /common internationally

### ### Drink

> flat cola 

not normally:

> dead cola 

### ### Conversation

> flat conversation 

while:

> dead conversation

would suggest something somewhat different and is much less standard.

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# Important distinction: **flat vs sharp — music**

In music:

#### ### **flat**

= lower in pitch

#### ### **sharp**

= higher in pitch

> sing flat = sing below the correct pitch

> sing sharp = sing above the correct pitch

This is a very useful technical contrast.

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# Family-extension note

The practical modern family includes:

\* \*\*flat\*\*  
\* \*\*flatter\*\*  
\* \*\*flattest\*\*  
\* \*\*flatten\*\*  
\* \*\*flattened\*\*  
\* \*\*flatly\*\*  
\* \*\*flatness\*\*

Useful compounds and expressions include:

\* flat surface  
\* flat tyre / tire  
\* flat battery  
\* flat drink  
\* flat rate  
\* flat fee  
\* flat refusal  
\* B-flat  
\* lie flat

The Golden Manual says different domains should be separated only when the learner genuinely needs a different mental concept, while closely related contextual variations should be merged.

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## # Master comparison

| Form / sense                      | MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning |
|-----------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| -----                             | -----                                 |
| **flat — physical shape/surface** | 表面、地形或物件沒有明顯彎曲、隆起、凹凸或突出部分的；平坦 / 平放的   |
| **flat — dull/lifeless**          | 缺乏活力、變化、情感或吸引力，因此令人覺得沉悶、單調或沒有感染力      |
| **flat drink**                    | 原本應有氣泡的飲品失去氣體，不再有氣泡感；走氣的              |
| **flat battery**                  | 電池沒有足夠電力供設備正常運作；沒電的                   |
| **flat tyre/tire**                | 輪胎因失去空氣或氣壓而變扁、不能保持正常形狀                |
| **flat — music**                  | 音高低於指定或正常音高；亦可指降半音                    |
| **flat rate/fee**                 | 不因使用量、時間或其他條件而改變的固定金額                 |
| **a flat — housing**              | 位於較大型建築物內、供一戶人居住的獨立住宅單位；英式英語          |
|                                   |                                       |
| **flat refusal/denial**           | 完全、直接而毫不含糊的拒絕或否定                      |
| **flatly**                        | 斷然地；亦可指毫無情緒或語調起伏地                     |
| **flatten**                       | 令某物變平、被壓倒或減少原本的突出 / 起伏                |

# For your original sentence

> "...conversations with him never feel \*\*flat\*\*."

The exact meaning is:

**\*\*flat = 缺乏活力、變化、情感或吸引力，令人感覺沉悶而沒有生氣\*\***

So:

> **\*\*conversation feels flat\*\***

= **\*\*談話令人覺得單調、沒有活力、缺乏起伏或感染力\*\***

For your database, I would count **\*\*8 genuinely useful core meanings\*\*** for **\*\*flat\*\***:

1. **\*\*physically level / not curved, raised, or uneven\*\***
2. **\*\*dull, lifeless, or lacking emotional/creative energy\*\***
3. **\*\*drink — no longer carbonated\*\***
4. **\*\*battery — discharged / no power\*\***
5. **\*\*tyre/tire — deflated\*\***
6. **\*\*music — lower in pitch / lowered by a semitone\*\***
7. **\*\*fixed and unvarying — flat rate / flat fee\*\***
8. **\*\*noun — apartment, especially British English\*\***

I would treat **\*\*flat refusal / flatly refuse\*\*** as a useful figurative extension of **\*\*complete/direct with no variation or qualification\*\***, rather than necessarily create a ninth core sense.